



Launching Apps at Quicksilver Speed

One of the most popular open source applications on the Mac platform is Quicksilver, an application launcher that remains a firm favourite among many users, notwithstanding a similar inbuilt feature in the Mac OS. We take a closer look at what makes it so special.

Mac users generally are extremely fanatical about their operating systems. In fact, many will point out that one of the reasons they switched to a Mac was because they liked the different interface and that the Mac OS manages to do so much more than its counterparts, and much faster at that. Of course, the Mac OS vs other open OSs argument is a perennial one, and not one that we propose to enter into now.

But even the Mac's perceived superiority has not stopped Mac users from using FOSS applications from time to time. And this is not only when the open source application provides functionality that is not inherent in the Mac OS (such as OpenOffice.org). Quicksilver is one such application that, in spite of having a counterpart in the Mac OS itself, is still popular among Mac users. So popular that it has inspired clones on other platforms—most famously, GNOME-Do on Linux.

Ready, set, launch!

In the simplest terms, Quicksilver is a launcher. It primarily helps users find and launch applications and access information and files on their systems. Of course, there is more, as we will find out. But first things first—getting Quicksilver is easy;

you can download the latest version of the application from getqs.blacktree.com. At less than 2 MB, it won't take much time and will install smoothly. Incidentally, Quicksilver is available for versions of the Mac OS going back to OS 10.3 (Panther), allowing those who have stayed with older versions (the latest is 10.5—Leopard) to use the application too, in the best FOSS tradition. Once installed, Quicksilver can be set to start at boot-up and can be invoked by a shortcut key combination (the default is space+control).

On launching, Quicksilver takes a bit of time (about the only occasion it does so) to create a catalogue of the applications and folders used most frequently by the user. Using it is extremely easy—just launch it and enter the name of the application, file or folder that you are looking for and even before you finish typing, Quicksilver will probably have thrown up the option that you are looking for. We can already hear some Mac users snigger, pointing out that the Mac OS' excellent search tool, Spotlight, does exactly the same thing. What makes Quicksilver special, however, is that it allows you to not just open the application, file or folder that you have found but also execute a whole series of commands involving it.